

# Banana Bread

Roast the bananas to concentrate them. Brown the butter for nutty Maillard depth. Trust the bicarbonate of soda — it neutralises the fruit’s acid and browns the crust.

Yield: **2 loaves** (23×13 cm)    Active: **25 min**    Total: **2 hr** (incl. roast + cool)    Oven: **175°C** (350°F)    Done: **95°C** internal

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                   |
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| <b>WHERE IT WAS BORN</b><br>1930s United States. The Depression made a black banana too precious to bin; cheap new bicarbonate of soda made a <i>quick bread</i> possible. First printed in Pillsbury’s <i>Balanced Recipes</i> , 1933. | <b>EATEN, AUTHENTICALLY</b><br>A home loaf, sliced thick with butter or toasted — best on days two and three. Spread the length of US, then Caribbean and UK home kitchens. | <b>HOW IT’S USED NOW</b><br>A cafe and galley staple worldwide; the same batter bakes into muffins (below). Note: today’s <i>Cavendish</i> replaced the lost <i>Gros Michel</i> . |
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## INGREDIENTS

WEIGHT ONLY · BAKER’S % / VOLUME IN RIGHT COLUMN

|                                          |      |       |
|------------------------------------------|------|-------|
| <b>DRY</b>                               |      |       |
| Plain flour ( <i>spoon &amp; level</i> ) | 480g | 100%  |
| Bicarbonate of soda ( <i>fresh</i> )     | 12g  | 2.5%  |
| Fine sea salt                            | 8g   | 1.7%  |
| Cinnamon ( <i>optional</i> )             | 4g   | 2 tsp |

|                                          |      |        |
|------------------------------------------|------|--------|
| <b>BROWN BUTTER, SUGAR &amp; MISO</b>    |      |        |
| Unsalted butter (~200g browned)          | 230g | 48%    |
| Light brown sugar                        | 300g | 63%    |
| Caster sugar                             | 100g | 21%    |
| White (shiro) miso ( <i>white only</i> ) | 60g  | 4 tbsp |

|                                    |      |       |
|------------------------------------|------|-------|
| <b>WET &amp; BANANA</b>            |      |       |
| Large eggs ( <i>room temp</i> )    | x4   | x4    |
| Vanilla extract ( <i>real</i> )    | 20g  | 4 tsp |
| Greek yoghurt ( <i>full-fat</i> )  | 120g | ½ cup |
| Very ripe bananas (→~680g roasted) | 900g | ~8    |

**THE RATIO — FLOUR = 100%**  
**Flour 100 · banana 142 · sugar 83 · fat 42 · egg 42 · soda 2.5.** Banana outweighs the flour — concentrate it by roasting and the crumb stays tender, not gummy.

Kit: 2 × 23×13 cm (9×5”) loaf tins · light-coloured saucepan · scale · instant-read probe · parchment slings.

## METHOD

1. **Roast the bananas whole.** 150°C (300°F), unpeeled, on a lined tray, until skins are **black** and flesh jammy, 25–30 min. Cool, peel, discard pooled liquid — ~680g flesh.

*Drives off ~25% of the banana’s water + caramelises sugars → concentrated flavour, no gummy crumb. — Stella Parks, Serious Eats 2017*

2. **Fold, divide, bake.** Whisk dry; fold into the wet (below) in two goes to **just combined** — flour streaks fine. Into 2 lined tins. **175°C (350°F), 50–60 min**, tent at 45 min if dark.

*Soda hits the banana’s acid and releases gas at once — get it to the oven; overmixing tightens the crumb. — McGee 2004*

**Brown butter, sugars & wet**

a. Melt 230g butter in a *light* pan, swirling, until milk solids turn golden-brown + smell of hazelnut, 6–8 min. Off heat at once; scrape every fleck out. — *Maillard, McGee 2004*

b. **Whisk in** 300g brown sugar, 100g caster, 60g white miso while warm, 2 min. *Miso glutamates amplify sweetness — undetectable at this dose. — ChefSteps 2018*

c. Beat in 4 eggs one at a time, then 20g vanilla + 120g yoghurt.

d. Mash the roasted banana roughly (lumps welcome) and stir through. Now fold in the dry mix.

**Done:** Centre **95°C** (203°F); skewer with moist crumbs, not wet batter. Top domed, cracked, deep golden — colour alone lies, trust the probe.  
**Serve:** cool in tin 15 min, lift out, cool 30 min before slicing. Best on days two and three. Freeze sliced, never the raw batter.

**ONE BATTER, TWO BAKES — BANANA MUFFINS**  
The same batter is ~24 muffins. Line a tray, fill each well **two-thirds**; bake **175°C (350°F), 22–25 min** to the same 95°C centre. Demerara on top for a crackled lid. *More surface per gram = faster browning, more edges.*

## ELEVATION

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <b>TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Espresso powder</b> — 1 tsp in the dry mix, deepens banana</li><li><b>Dark brown sugar</b> — swap 1:1, more molasses</li><li><b>Sour cream for yoghurt</b> — richer, denser</li></ul> | <b>TIER 2 — WORTH IT</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Tahini swirl</b> — 3 tbsp dragged across the top</li><li><b>Miso–BB glaze</b> — 2 tbsp BB + 1 tbsp miso + icing sugar</li><li><b>Caribbean turn</b> — rum raisins, lime zest, allspice</li></ul> | <b>TIER 3 — RESTAURANT</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Brown-butter streusel</b> — rubbed crumbs, scattered on top</li><li><b>Brûléed slice</b> — sugar + torch, to order</li><li><b>Banana powder</b> — freeze-dried, over warm slices</li></ul> |
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## TROUBLESHOOT

|                 |                                                                   |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dense, tough    | Overmixed or too much flour. Fold to just-combined; weigh flour.  |
| Gummy band      | Banana water. Roast it; pour off pooled liquid before mashing.    |
| Sunken middle   | Under-baked or too wet. Bake to a true 95°C internal.             |
| Pale & sour     | Too little soda or oven cool. Weigh soda; verify 175°C.           |
| Soapy, metallic | Too much soda. Measure it — banana acid neutralises only so much. |
| Sticks to tin   | No sling. Parchment with overhang lifts clean.                    |

## CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

|                       |                                                                 |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The make-ahead</b> | <b>Roast banana in bulk; the loaf is then a 25-min job.</b>     |
| <b>Roasted banana</b> | Mash warm, 340g bags, freeze flat 3 mo. Thaw overnight, fridge. |
| <b>Dry mix</b>        | Airtight, RT, 1 mo. Brown butter: fridge 2 wk, re-melt.         |
| <b>Baked, sliced</b>  | Wrap/seal, freeze 3 mo. Toast from frozen or 10 min / 150°C.    |
| <b>Hold</b>           | Wrapped at RT — better on days 2–3 than day one.                |
| <b>Never</b>          | Freeze the raw batter — soda dies; the loaf sits flat.          |